

221 - Stars, Planets, and Black Holes

Podcast: secular buddhism

AI Executive Summary

Core Thesis Using the cosmic phenomena of stars, planets, and black holes as metaphors, the episode explores the Buddhist principle of interdependence to describe human psychological states. The host argues that humans are not fixed, independent identities but shifting "weather" within an interconnected web (Indra's Net). By understanding that our capacities to reflect, transform, or consume energy are temporary states driven by changing causes and conditions, we can develop greater compassion for ourselves and others.

Key Arguments & Data

- * **The Three Cosmic Modes of Human Experience:**
 - * **Planet Mode (Reflecting):** A state of mirroring the environment. Humans in this mode reflect the energy, moods, and stressors of those around them. The quality of this reflection depends on "clarity"—how much "dust" or "clay" (mental conditioning/ego) obscures the individual's ability to reflect clearly.
 - * **Star Mode (Transforming):** A generative state where input is converted into something new and radiant. Using examples like the Artemis II moon mission crew and the characters in *Project Hail Mary*, the host illustrates how individuals can transform their circumstances and training into warmth, service, and profound connection to others.
 - * **Black Hole Mode (Consuming):** A state of extreme contraction, driven by intense grief, trauma, or the "three poisons" (craving and aversion). In this mode, energy is drawn inward and does not emerge; however, the host emphasizes this is a state of "critical density" rather than a permanent personality trait.
- * **The Principle of Interdependence:** * The host cites the Buddhist formula: *"This is because that is; this is not because that is not."* Nothing arises in isolation; every phenomenon (a flower, a human, a star) is the result of infinite nested causes and conditions. *
- * **Indra's Net:** An allegory for reality where an infinite web of jewels reflects every other jewel in the net, illustrating that there is no "edge" or "center" to identity; we are all interconnected reflections.
- * **Scientific & Biological Evidence of Non-Self:** * The host points to the human microbiome—noting that microbial cells roughly equal human cells and that gut bacteria significantly influence serotonin production—to argue that the biological boundary between "self" and "environment" is a conceptual convenience

rather than a physical reality. * **The Concept of "Sunyata" (Emptiness):** * Drawing on the idea that we are "processes" (verbs) rather than "entities" (nouns), the host suggests that identity is fluid. Using Pema Chödrön's metaphor, the host argues we should strive to be the "sky" (the observing awareness) rather than the "weather" (the transient emotional states).

Actionable Takeaways * Practice Non-Judgmental Self-Auditing:

Periodically pause to ask, *"What mode am I in right now: planet, star, or black hole?"* Use this as a tool for honest observation of your current psychological conditions rather than a way to label yourself negatively. *

Apply "Condition-Based" Empathy in Conflict: When navigating difficult relationships, attempt to view the other person's behavior as a temporary "weather pattern" caused by their current life conditions. Asking *"What state are they experiencing?"* can change your response from reactive to compassionate. * **Focus on "Polishing the Jewel":** Rather than trying to force yourself to be a permanent "star," focus on the practice of clearing away the "dust" of conditioning and reactivity. The goal is to maintain enough clarity so that you can effectively reflect and transform the energy passing through you.

Full Transcript

The Secular Buddhism podcast is now on EightfoldPath.com. With transcripts, AI chat, and more, visit EightfoldPath.com. Hello and welcome to another episode of The Secular Buddhism podcast. This is episode number 221. I am your host, Noah Rasheda, and today I'm talking about stars, planets, and black holes. The title may throw you for a second, but stick with me because this episode is really about three ways of being human and how the cosmos turns out to be a surprisingly good map for it. As always, remember you don't need to use what you learn from Buddhism to be a Buddhist. You can use what you learn to simply be a better whatever you already are. Hey, before we get into today's episode, I want to share something I'm really excited about.

One of the questions I get asked most often by listeners of the podcast is whether I host retreats somewhere that you can come and actually spend time with this practice in person and not just in your earbuds or headphones. And the answer is yes. And I'm excited to announce that the next one is coming up this fall, Thursday, September 10th through Sunday, the 13th. I'm hosting a four day retreat at Dralla Mountain Center in the mountains of northern Colorado. It's called already whole, discovering the freedom within. The whole retreat is built around a single question. What if the piece you've been searching for is already inside you? Just covered up by the layers we accumulate over a lifetime. The certainty, the labels, and what we call conditioning. Last year's retreat was the first one that I've ever done of this kind and it sold out.

And this year, I added an entire day. You don't need any prior experience with meditation or Buddhism. If you listen to this podcast, you already have everything you need to show up. All the details, the schedule, what's included, lodging options, everything are available at eightfoldpath.com forward slash retreats. That's eightfoldpath.com forward slash retreats. And back to our show. My mind has been in the cosmos. for the last several weeks, and a few things put it there. First, I gave a Dharma talk on interdependence, and then I watched a film that I haven't been able to stop thinking about. And the third event, like many of you, I watched four

people last month go around the moon and come home, and I found myself unexpectedly affected by what I saw. And so did a lot of people.

therapists were getting asked in interviews, why were we all crying about a moon mission? And one answer I heard stayed with me. A therapist said, this story doesn't represent technological progress so much as a different kind of story about humanity, where it's collaborative, not combative. And we saw people working together across disciplines, across setbacks and still choosing to move forward. That kind of story feels almost unfamiliar right now, she said, which is precisely why it lands so deeply. And I think she was right. And I think there's something underneath her answer that's worth sitting with. So I want to talk through all three with you today. The mission, the film I watched, and then the Dharma talk on interdependence, because I think they're saying the same thing. They're describing three different ways.

human being can show up in the world, three different modes, three different relationships to the light around us, and I'll get into all of that. But let's start with the first one, the one that most of you or perhaps many of you watched, and that's the Artemis II mission to orbit the moon. So here are the basic facts. There were four astronauts, three Americans and a Canadian. They were Reed Wiseman, Victor Glover, Christina Koch, and Jeremy Hansen. And they launched on April 1st of this year. And they went to the moon, they flew around it and returned home. And they were the first humans to leave low Earth orbit since 1972. They were the first humans in over 50 years to see the far side of the moon with their own eyes.

And they came home 10 days later, splashed down off the coast in San Diego and walked into a world of new experiences and celebrations and hugs. Everybody was really excited for them. But the mission summary wasn't what moved me. When the mission started, I got sucked into watching it because YouTube was live streaming it. And it was incredible to watch footage of something that was happening so far away. And before I knew it, I was feeling all the feels and I was emotionally moved by what I was witnessing. And one of the strongest moments for me happened on Flight Day 6. The crew had spotted some unnamed characters on the lunar surface. and they decided to propose names for them. Lunar features are typically named after deceased scientists or explorers or engineers. And the

crew radioed Mission Control, and Jeremy Hansen spoke for four of them. And he said, and I want to read this as he said it, he said, a number of years ago, we started this journey in our close-knit astronaut family. And we lost a loved one. Her name was Carol, the spouse of Reed.

the mother of Katie and Ellie. Carol Wiseman was Reed Wiseman's wife, and she died of cancer in 2020 at 46 years old, and she was a NICU nurse, the Neonatal Intensive Care Unit. This is the nurse who sits with patients at the worst moments of their lives, watching over babies who might not make it, and that was her job. That's what she did. When she passed she left behind two daughters and a husband who would six years later be the commander of this first crewed mission beyond low orbit. And that's Artemis too. So Hansen described the crater they were looking at and he said it was a bright spot on the moon and he said we would like to call it Carol. And boy was that moving. I got I think everyone watching was teary-eyed. There were 45 seconds of silence from mission control. 45 seconds. The livestream showed the crew floating in zero gravity, putting their arms around each other. Wiseman was wiping tears from his eyes. They were all wiping tears from their eyes. And then after that, 45 seconds of silence, Capcom came on.

And the woman whose job that day was to be the voice of mission control and said integrity and Carol Or integrity and Carol crater loud and clear. Thank you. I think it moved everyone there Who was watching and later and I still get emotional thinking about it Later when when Wiseman was talking about it He said it was the most beautiful thing he had ever heard. He said the the three other crew members had planned it before launch Hansen had pulled him aside and told him what they wanted to do and Wiseman asked man What man on this planet deserves a gift like that to have your crew be so thoughtful so caring and so deep And again, it was just really touching here. We had four people more than 250,000 miles from earth furthest that humans had ever been from home. And they were carrying their crewmates grief with them with a purpose, naming a bright spot on the moon for a woman that wasn't there because she was the wife of a man who was flying with them. And that's the first moment. That was one of the most touching moments. But there were more. Another moment

happened after they came back. They had splashed down, and I think the crew was processing the...

the intensity of what they had experienced and they did a press release or a press appearance in Houston and Christina took the microphone and she said when we saw tiny earth people asked our crew what impressions we had and honestly what struck me wasn't necessarily just earth it was all the blackness around it earth was just this lifeboat hanging undisturbingly in the universe and she got choked up at that moment. She said, I know I haven't learned everything that this journey has yet to teach me, but there's one new thing I know, and that is, Planet Earth, you are a crew. And then she defined what she meant. She said, a crew is a group that is in it all the time, no matter what, that is stroking together every minute with the same purpose, that is willing to sacrifice silently for each other, that gives grace, that holds accountable. A crew has the same cares and the same needs. A crew is inescapably, beautifully, dutifully linked." And that was a second impactful moment watching this whole thing. And the third one was actually right after this one where Jeremy Hansen asked his crewmates to stand with him. And the four of them lined up, arms around each other, shoulders, and Hansen turned to the crowd. And he said, I would suggest to you that when you look up here, You're not looking at us. We are a mirror reflecting you. And if you like what you see, then just look a little deeper. This is you. So I just loved watching this whole mission unfold. There was the moment of the naming of Carol Crater. There was the message that Planet Earth, you are a crew. And the we are a mirror reflecting you. This is you. And just hold those thoughts for a moment. The second.

thing that's been on my mind with the cosmos, aside from watching the Artemis mission, was the timing of the film called Project Hail Mary. This is based on the novel by Andy Weir, the same person who wrote the Martian. And it came out a couple of weeks before Artemis 2 launched. And if you haven't seen it and you don't know anything about it, you might want to skip ahead. There's a light spoiler when I get to the end of what I'm going to explain here. But here's the basic setup. There's a microorganism in space that's eating the sun's energy. Earth has a few years before temperatures collapse, civilization. And a small mission is going to be sent to a nearby star system that for reasons that no one understands is not being

affected by that microorganism. So the mission is a one-way trip. It's whoever goes is...

unlikely to come home. And the main character is Ryland Grace. He's played by Ryan Gosling. He's a middle school science teacher with exactly the expertise the mission needs. So they ask him to go, but he doesn't want to go. He refuses. And that's the part that stood out to me is that he just doesn't have anyone on earth he's willing to die for. He has no spouse, no children, no close family. So when they ask him to volunteer for this mission that will probably kill him in order to save the species, he says no. And he's told, you know, don't be a coward. Eventually, he was put on board essentially against his will and arrives at the destination alone. He wakes up from the induced coma, discovers He's actually not the only one there trying to solve this. There's another civilization that sent their own version of that same mission and he encounters another being that he named Rocky. And Grace and Rocky share almost nothing. They can't share the same air without one of them dying. They can't touch. They can't communicate. They don't have a common language, common biology or a common evolution. And yet they figure things out. They build a chamber so they can be in proximity.

through a transparent barrier, they figure out how to communicate, they figure out how to work the problem together, and in the process, they become friends. In fact, the deepest friendship that either of them has probably ever had. And that's a moment that comes back over and over. Grace says, I'm alone and Rocky corrects him, only us. And now the light spoiler here, if you, you know, Skip this if you want to be surprised if you haven't watched the movie yet, but at the end of the story, Grace has a choice. He can continue home to earth having saved humanity, having done exactly what was asked of him. Or he can turn back to save Rocky's life because Rocky's life is in danger without help and Rocky will die before he gets home if Grace doesn't do anything about it. So Grace turns back. The man who had no one on earth he was willing to die for He gave up returning home to Earth. He gave up everything for one specific being that he had befriended from a whole other world, a being who they don't even speak each other's language. And what's interesting is Grace didn't bring

that capacity with him on the trip. He didn't board the spacecraft already willing to die for someone. That capacity formed out there.

on the mission, out of conditions, out of proximity, out of the simple fact that he and Rocky had nowhere else to go. And they had a shared problem that mattered to them both and they had figured it out. So connection isn't a feature that you have or you don't have. It's a process that unfolds when the situation holds two people together long enough with care. around a problem that matters. And the physics of the story is the teaching. The only reason Grace and Rocky ever meet is that their sons are dying and their species' fates are woven into each other before either of them was even aware of it. Maybe before they were even born. The interdependence wasn't optional. It was the situation. They just lived through it subjectively through friendship. And then the third thing that's been on my mind with the cosmos comes from a Dharma talk I gave a few months back on the topic of interdependence, and the Buddha put it as a formula. He said, this is because that is, and this is not because that is not.

The understanding here is that nothing arises on its own. Everything that exists does so because of causes and conditions. A flower, for example, is possible because of the seed, the soil, the rain, the sunlight, the temperature, the season. If you remove any of those, then there's no flower. But each of those things has its own causes and conditions. Rain, for example, is possible because of weather systems. The soil is possible because of geological time. The sunlight is possible because a particular star at a particular distance with a particular mass. So everything is nested inside everything else. And there's no bottom, right? There's no single first cause. And the image that I use in that Dharma talk to convey this, comes from Huayan Buddhism and it's a teaching about Indra's net. So you imagine an infinite net stretching in every direction with no center, with no edge, no beginning, no end. At every intersection of the threads where the threads cross there's a jewel and there's an infinite number of jewels in an infinite web and each jewel reflects every other jewel.

not just the ones nearby, it's every single one. And each of those reflections reflects every other jewel infinitely and in every direction. So what do you see when you look at one jewel? You see the reflection of every other jewel,

you see the whole net, you see all of it. And this is an image that I like to think about, but it's true with with interdependence, that this is because that is, everything is connected to everything else. Think about yourself for a moment, your body. Most of the genetic material operating inside what you call your body right now is not even human. The number of microbial cells in your body roughly matches the number of human cells. So you have bacteria, fungi, organisms that you'll never meet, that you cannot even see. And the number of microbial genes operating inside you is about 150 times the number of human genes. That's just what's happening in your gut. And your gut produces about 95% of the body's serotonin, and the bacteria living there plays a major role in regulating it. So in a very real way, your mood is determined by bacteria in your stomach. It's fascinating. This idea of where exactly does you end and not you begin.

I don't think you can find the line because there isn't one. The boundary that we assume is there, the clear edge between the sense of self and not self, between what we would say is inside and outside, turns out to be a conceptual convenience that's maintained by a mind that finds separation more comfortable than connection. So in this sense, Indra's net isn't just a metaphor about invisible connections. It's a description of what's structurally and mechanically true about reality, that one thing is because of something else. And that going back to the Artemis mission, that's what Jeremy Hansen meant when he said, we are a mirror reflecting you. This is you. I don't think he was just speaking poetically. He was describing what is structurally the case.

for reality that, you know, think of the four astronauts are made of the same elements as the rest of us. They were trained by people who were taught by other people going back generations. They were carried into space by a vehicle that was built by thousands of engineers. Their food that they ate was grown by farmers. Their suits they were wearing were sewn by garment workers. the very courage that they had was made possible by people who loved them and held them together long enough for them to be willing to risk that much to go do what they were going to do. And when you look at that, what you see is interdependence, right? You look at the four of them and you really are looking at all of us. Hansen was reading off

of the structure of reality. It's the same in the movie with the characters, Grace and Rocky. They weren't connected because they just decided to be.

They were connected because the dying of two different stars had already woven their species' fates together before either of them was aware of it. And they just lived that connection through as friendship. And with my thoughts turned to the cosmos for all these past weeks, I've been spending a lot of time looking at the night sky. Sometimes that night I'll go sit outside in the hot tub and I'll just look up. because where I live it's really dark and we have a really wonderful view of the stars. And I'll sit there and I think about what is it that I'm actually seeing? When you look at the night sky, you see light. But not all of it is light of the same kind of light. Some of what you see is light being generated, nuclear fusion happening inside of stars, millions or billions of light years away. And those stars are genuine sources of light, of radiance.

and they're converting hydrogen and helium and releasing energy and some of which eventually reaches your eye after traveling these unimaginable distances through space. But here's what's interesting. Some of the light you see is reflected light. Jupiter, for example, on certain nights is the brightest object in the sky, brighter than almost any star. But Jupiter doesn't generate light. So what you see when you're looking at Jupiter is the Sun's light. bounced off of Jupiter's atmosphere traveling across the solar system to reach you, to reach your eyes. But it's the sun in that case wearing Jupiter as the mirror. It's the same with the moon. On a full moon night, it can be bright enough that the landscape is lit up and you can be walking without a flashlight. But the moon is not generating any light, right? It just happens to be in the right place and it acts as a reflective surface. And then you have black holes.

And we can't really see those out there, at least not with a naked eye. Black holes don't reflect. They're not generating light. They are regions of spacetime where gravity has become so intense that nothing, not even light, can escape. Everything that approaches beyond a certain threshold is drawn in and it doesn't come back out. So black holes consume. And I thought of these three fundamentally different modes of relating to light in the universe where you have stars stars generate light through transformation you have

planets and moons that reflect light whatever light comes to them. Then you have black holes that are consuming light and drawing everything inward and as I was sitting there looking up I realized you know these are.

These aren't just astrological phenomena. These represent human experiences. These are states that every one of us cycles through. So most of us, most of the time, maybe we're in planet mode and we're reflecting, right? We're reflecting the light around us, reflecting the conditions around us and our mood mirrors the mood of the room. Our energy responds to the energy that we encounter and we pick up the stress of people that we love and that becomes our stress. or the energy, and we absorb the warmth of a good conversation, and it lifts us. And we're not necessarily generating anything particularly new, we're receiving and passing along. That's the quality of what we pass along, and it depends largely on how clear we are, how clean the jewel is. Going back to the jewel analogy in Indra's Net, the jewel reflects the light of every other jewel.

But if the jewel is covered in dust or covered in clay, that affects what gets reflected back. So that was one way of thinking of all of this as we reflect the light. But then sometimes something shifts in us, whether it's through practice or personality or just causes and conditions. Sometimes we can be more like the planet. or the star, I should say. And sometimes the star, let's call this star mode, now you're not just reflecting, you're transforming what you've received into something. You're generating light. I think we all know people like this that feel like they're in star mode. And these might be teachers that you've encountered, best friends that you might have, people that just leave you feeling more alive.

than when you arrived. And I think they're doing something with what they've received. And that output is genuinely warm. It's like light. And I like to think of that as star mode. And then you have the black holes. And these, again, are moments that many of us at some point will feel. And when we're in black hole mode, the ordinary dynamics of exchange break down, right? Instead of reflecting or transforming or creating, the energy just goes in and it doesn't come out. These are states where it feels very difficult, if not impossible, to be present for anyone, because you can barely be present for yourself. I think of things like grief at certain intensities

might feel like this. Trauma responds the three poisons, especially craving and aversion. It can create something that feels like a gravitational collapse.

the consuming overwhelms any ability to reflect or to create light. And I want to be clear here that doesn't mean that the person is bad. You know, it means the conditions of their inner world have reached a critical density. So I keep thinking about why the Artemis mission was such a profound experience for myself and for many of us. Again, most of us most of the time are in planet mode. some of us more often than we want to admit are in something close to black hole mode. The cultural backdrop has been so saturated for quite a long time now with the latter that we kind of forgot what the alternative even looks like. And then we watched four people in star mode, right? The crew.

not heroes, not super humans, just four highly capable, competent people channeling what they had received from their training, from the experience they were having, from each other, from people on the ground, and from everyone who had ever helped them to get there into something generative. They were good at something. And more importantly, they were good to each other while doing it. And it was like seeing these four humans in star mode just creating light. It was a beautiful thing to watch. I think Star Mode together, right? And that's what I enjoyed about watching the movie Project Hail Mary and the characters Grace and Rocky. That's what they did. There's the smallest crew, two beings who couldn't even share an atmosphere, shared a project and they made it work together. Star Mode on the scale of two people.

And then in the interview later, when Christina said the word crew, that that's what she was describing, that all of us here on earth, she wasn't talking about a job title, she was describing what star mode looks like when more than one person is doing it at the same time and in the same direction and for the same reason. And I really like that. And I think even when we are in star mode, you're still in the net, right? Even stars don't generate their own light from nothing. They're converting hydrogen leftover from older stars that exploded and seeded the universe with the elements that built them. And even the most radiant object in the cosmos is still something that's receiving and transforming. It has causes and conditions. And the

Artemis crew did not create themselves. The characters in the movie didn't create their own capacity to love or to generate friendship. It was the conditions that came to be.

that delivered them to the moment. They responded skillfully to what had arrived. It's like I always say, life gives us Tetris pieces. It's what we do with those pieces. That's what star mode is. It's not self-sufficiency. It's just a particular kind of relationship that you develop with whatever it is that you've been given. And in this case, all the elements are there for the star to be able to produce light. And I want to emphasize here, when I'm thinking of this, I'm thinking of states. These are states, the stars, black holes, planets, like these are states, not identities. It's not like this person is a star and this person is a, no, we're all of these things and we all go through the various states. And I think that they shift and change and rotate through time. I know I've spent time in every one of those states producing light that helps others being a simple reflection that gives off the light of what I've received from someone else or that's coming from somewhere else. And I've certainly been at times the black hole that's like, I just, I can't put anything out, not even a reflection. I'm just taking it all in and absorbing it. And the mind loves to assign permanence, right? The mind wants to label, oh, she's a star. Oh, he's a black hole. Oh, me, I'm just a reflective planet.

And that feels like understanding because the mind likes to file things and then call it done. Be like, okay, I know you, you're this or you're that. But that's not what we should do here with these understandings of the stars, planets, black holes. Permanent categorization is exactly what interdependence pushes back against. Going back to Reed Wiseman, The crew member whose wife had died in 2020, when his wife had passed away, he was almost certainly not in star mode, right? He was probably going through a difficult black hole mode. And the conditions of his life had collapsed. He had two young daughters who had just lost their mother. He had a career that required him to stay operationally excellent. And while he was going through, it was probably one of the worst chapters of his life.

those are causes and conditions. Whatever he was doing internally during that time, it was probably not generative warmth or light. Maybe it was just survival mode. Maybe it was simple reflection. I don't know. The point is

conditions change. And for him, conditions had changed because of what he was going through. And conditions always change. We know that they always do. And then six years later, he was floating in a spacecraft more than 200,000 miles away from Earth. putting his arm around the man whose voice was naming a crater on the moon for his wife. It's the same man, two different conditions, two different places in space and time, right? And at that point in that embrace, it looked like a star giving off light. And I just love to think of that, that we're going to go through and transition through these various stages in life. In the movie, it's the same.

in our own individual lives, it's the same. Something I love about the movie actually is the character at the beginning had no one on earth he was willing to die for, right? He would not have turned that ship around. And he didn't have the capacity to do that yet. But the man at the end of that story, the same man, different conditions at that point, had the capacity. He didn't bring it with him. It was developed there. And I think even the most consuming object in the universe, the black hole, isn't permanent. Stephen Hawking proposed what's now called Hawking radiation over almost unimaginable time scales, and black holes emit particles at their event horizon, and they lose mass, and eventually, theoretically, they evaporate entirely. So the most collapsed object in the known universe still eventually gives something back.

a fascinating thought. So when you encounter someone or you notice you yourself or in that black hole mode, what that tells you is that the conditions of that person's life have reached a state of gravitational collapse. It's a description of conditions. It's not a verdict on who they are. It's not a label because conditions can change. They sometimes do. Eventually they will. That's just the nature of reality. So when you do find yourself in one of these states, which you will, we all will at some point, the same thing is true of you. It's the recognition that this too shall pass. But to be skillful with whatever state you're in. You know, if I know I'm kind of in a black hole moment right now in life, I can navigate that skillfully because I know I'm in the black hole state. And I want to be careful to not consume your energy and devour it, right? Like I want to be skillful in my relationship with you because I know that I'm in a black hole state, for example. And the state is not the self, right? In Buddhism, we've got this word for the teaching of

emptiness, and it's sunyata, and it's translated as emptiness. It's the observation that nothing has a fixed independent self-contained existence. You don't exist the way you think you do. You're more like a process than you are a thing.

you're more like a verb than you are a noun. And Pema Shodran put it like this, which I've always liked. She says, you are the sky. Everything else, it's just the weather. The sky doesn't fight the storm. The sky makes room for the storm to exist and to move and to grow, to intensify and ultimately to dissipate. The sky is not threatened by the weather because the sky is not the weather. And I think there's something in you that can observe your own states that can notice when you're in planet mode, when you're in star mode, when you're in black hole mode. And it's that noticing, that awareness, the awareness itself is not one of those states. It's the sky watching the weather. A planet can't just decide to become a star. A black hole can't just choose to radiate light. A human being, though, in the grip of even the most difficult or contracted consuming state that you might find yourself in, does have the ability to observe and through that observation, perhaps to pause and perhaps to notice and name what it is that's happening. And that moment of noticing is the beginning of something. It's where the polishing of the jewel actually starts, right? Each jewel in Indra's net. So the Artemis crew named a feature on the moon for a woman who couldn't be there to see it herself. And they did that on a mission that was already historic.

In a moment, they could have spent on anything else, but they chose to spend it on each other. And I love that. And in the film, Grace turned a ship around. He gave up coming home for one specific being who couldn't survive in his atmosphere and whose language he didn't even speak. And in both of those stories, one's real and one's not, one's fiction, but both are about love and friendship across distance and in spite of differences. They're both about people who chose. And that is what humans can do for each other across distance and time. That is what Indra's net does when it's working. It reflects. Every jewel reflects the light of every other jewel. And you are in this net. You can't opt out of it.

Every moment you are reflecting or transforming or drawing inward and all of it enters a system whose full effects you'll never see. You won't see most

of your impact. The ripples that you send into this web are beyond your ability to trace. A moment of genuine presence in someone's life becomes a condition in their life that shapes something that you might never even know what it shaped or how it shaped it. You're a planet. You're occasionally a star. you're occasionally a black hole. And that's also true about everyone that you know, everyone that you love, everyone that's ever hurt you. And none of those are permanent. The work of practice isn't to become one over another. It's not to become a star and stay there. That would be its own form of grasping. And even stars eventually go supernova. So the work is really to keep polishing the jewel in the net, to notice when dust or grime collects and accumulates.

and to clean it, to polish it off, to be an effective reflection of everything that's there, to cultivate the conditions that help you move from one state to another, from feeling contracted to feeling open, and from consuming to maybe reflecting, and from reflecting maybe to generating or creating light. And none of those are permanent, right? You don't need to be the source, you just need to be clear enough to let that source through. So, Before I go, two things that I would encourage you to try this week. Ask yourself from time to time, what mode am I in right now? Am I planet mode, star mode, black hole? And don't do this as a form of judgment. Just do an honest look at your current conditions. And then pick one relationship in your life that is confusing or difficult and ask the same question about the other person. Again, don't do this as a permanent label.

Do it as a description of the conditions that they seem to be experiencing at this given moment in life. And ask yourself, what does knowing that this is an impermanent thing with causes and conditions, what does that change about how I show up for this person? I know they're in the state of being a black hole or they're in the state of being a star or a planet, right? How does that knowing that that's what's happening? How does that change how I show up for this person? And remember, you are always a condition in someone else's weather. The question is, what kind? That's all I've got for this episode. Thank you for listening. Until next time. Thank you for listening to the secular Buddhism podcast. If you'd like to read the full transcript of this episode, explore guided meditations, or just take a deeper dive into the teachings, visit eightfoldpath.com. There you'll find

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